

German Labor Market: East-West Convergence

Bronze → Silver → Gold pipeline on real German unemployment data, 1956–2025

Tools

Python • Pandas • matplotlib — pipeline structured the same way as the German Motorcycle Market Analysis and German Electricity Market Analysis projects (Bronze/Silver/Gold Medallion architecture).

Data sources

- Statistisches Bundesamt (Destatis), "Lange Reihen" series — Registrierte Arbeitslose und Arbeitslosenquote nach Gebietsstand, sourced from Statistik der Bundesagentur für Arbeit. Annual unemployment count and rate for Germany, former West Germany, and the new federal states (former East Germany), 1956–2025.
- Statistisches Landesamt Baden-Württemberg press release, "Arbeitslosigkeit 2025 erneut gestiegen" — a handful of individual 2025 state-level rates explicitly quoted in the release.

Key findings

- **The East-West unemployment gap has narrowed from 10.8 percentage points at its widest (2001: East 18.8% vs West 8.0%) to just 2.2pp in 2025 (East 8.6% vs West 6.4%)** — real convergence, though the gap hasn't fully closed even 35 years after reunification.
- **Nationwide unemployment has risen for three straight years:** 5.8% (2022) → 6.2% (2023) → 6.5% (2024) → 6.8% (2025).
- **The 1956-2025 view puts today's rate in historical context:** still well below the mid-2000s Hartz-reform-era peak (11.0% in 2005) and the 2009 financial-crisis level (8.7%), but above the pre-pandemic low of 5.1% (2019).
- **State-level spread in 2025 is wide:** from 4.0% in Bavaria to 11.5% in Bremen, an almost 3x difference within one country.

Charts

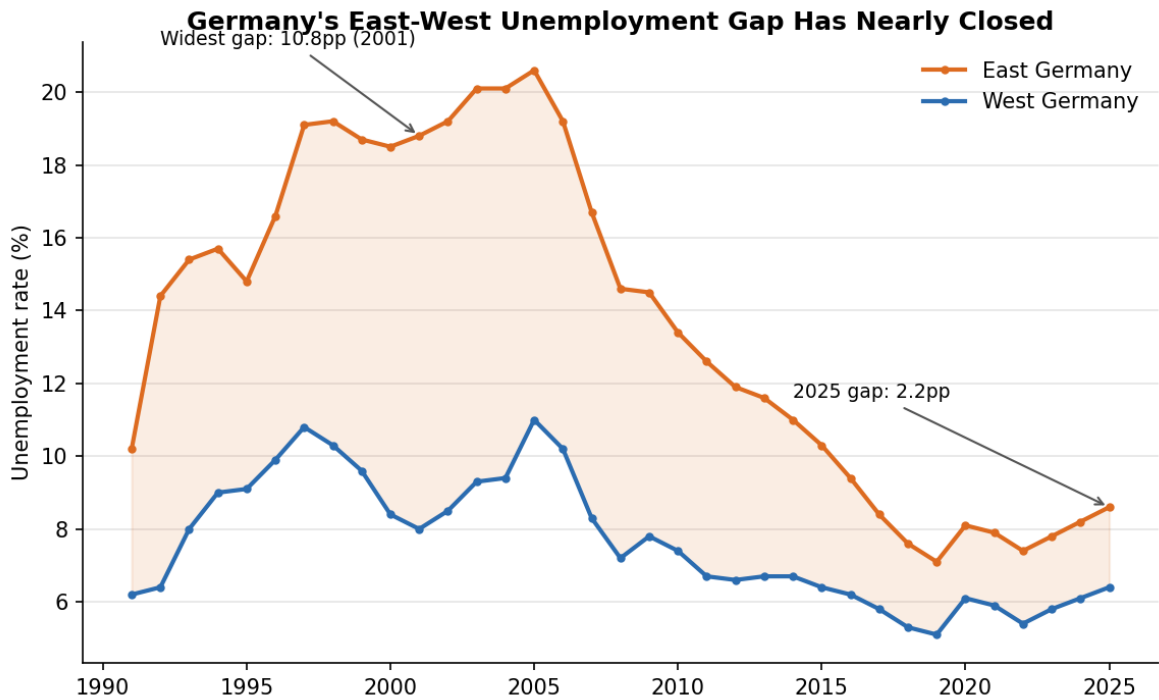


Figure 1. East vs West Germany unemployment rate, 1991-2025, with the year-by-year gap shaded.



Figure 2. West Germany / Germany unemployment rate, 1956-2025, with key economic events flagged.

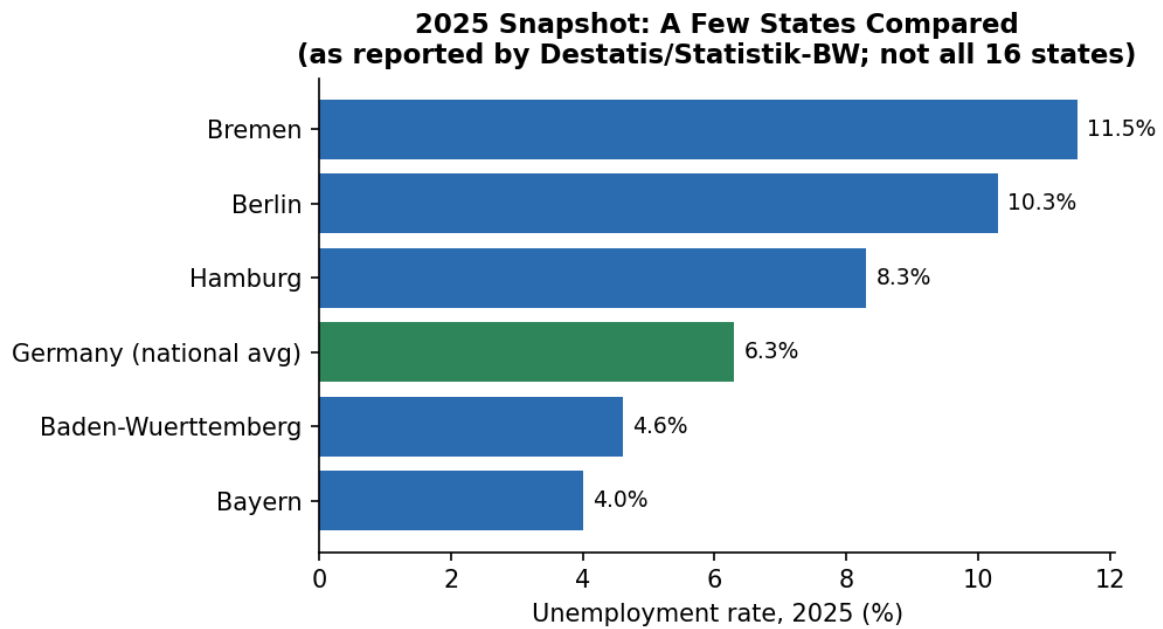


Figure 3. 2025 snapshot of individual states explicitly reported by Destatis/Statistik-BW (partial, not all 16 states).

Notes on data

The West/East/Germany annual series (1956-2025) is complete and official. The 2025 individual-state snapshot is partial by nature of the source — it includes only the states a Baden-Württemberg state-statistics press release happened to name with an exact figure, alongside the national average; it is presented as a snapshot, not a full 16-state ranking. A natural follow-up would pull the complete state-by-state series from Destatis GENESIS-Online (registration required for full API access).